anything more than a symbolic manifestation of Tamil culture.

'Here,' wrote Pillai, 'we find the extraordinary phenomenon of almost the entire Tamil race of the present day enthroning Agastya, an Aryan Rishi, in a rank little removed from that of divinity and paying him homage as to one of their own kith and kin … The whole extent of Tamil Classical literature has not one word to say about Agastya, or his literary labours … The only possible explanation for this phenomenon of general silence is that at that time there did not exist even a scrap of the Agastya tradition.'[13]

Since Pillai wrote those words nothing has appeared by way of evidence to challenge his argument that the Tamil Agathya is a product of wishful thinking. As for the Sanskrit Agastya, he remains firmly established at his hermitage on Mahendra Giri or Pothigai Malai – or, as it is much better known today, Agastya Malai. His squat statue is now enshrined on the summit of the highest peak in the range and is an object of pilgrimage, accessible only by three days of hard climbing. Women are not allowed near Agastya mountain, for fear of polluting it.

This Agastya represents the arrival of Sanskritic culture in the South in the persons of Brahmins with their Vedic gods – quite possibly under a religious leader named Agastya but not necessarily so. But underlying it is another less obvious story, about an earlier migration of pre-Arya or post-Harappan peoples from the North. Some of them might well have been refugees from a catastrophic inundation on the Kathiawar coast. Either way, they brought with them their non-Sanskrit languages and their deities: chiefly mother figures, but also one priapic fertility god of many aspects, as a lord of yogis, as a hunter and as a lord of all creatures.